



Poor planning: The Club World Cup has seen extreme weather conditions that have led to games being suspended for prolonged periods. AP

on how far they reach in European and domestic competitions.

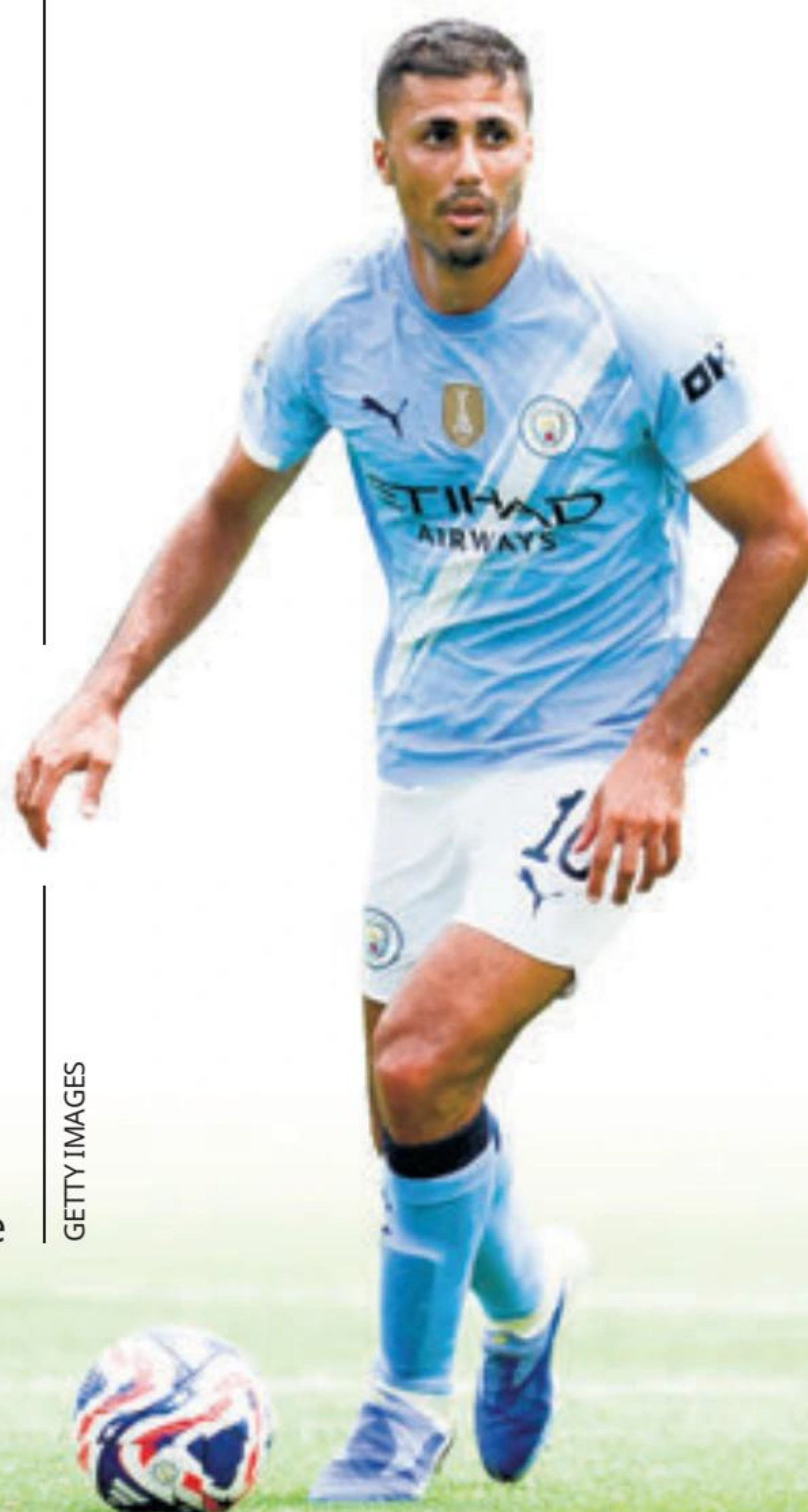
Adding a 63-match tournament after that, albeit once every four years, is a stark indication of how players have become secondary in the modern game, which is now driven by business models and revenue.

Outside Europe, the Campeonato Brasileiro Série A, the top flight in Brazilian football, has a 38-match league. Unlike European leagues, teams competing here have their season running parallel to the CWC, meaning players of Botafogo, Palmeiras, Flamengo and Fluminense

(who played the most CWC matches, having reached the semifinal) had to shoulder a significant extra workload on top of the strains of league football and domestic competitions.

Former Liverpool manager Jurgen Klopp said this when asked about his views on the rebrand: "It's all about the game and not the surrounding events. That's why the CWC is the worst idea ever implemented in football in this regard. People who have never had or do not have anything to do with day-to-day business anymore are coming up with something. There is insane money for participating, but it's also not for every club. Last year it was the Copa America and the European Championship, this year it's the CWC, and next year the World Cup. That means no real recovery for the players involved, neither physically nor mentally."

Last September, Manchester City midfielder Rodri (**below**), who had a longer season after his title-winning EURO 2024 campaign with Spain, said players were close to going on strike because of the increase in games. Just a week later, he suffered a torn ACL in a 2-2 draw against Arsenal and was initially supposed to miss the rest of the season. However, due to a good recovery, he could return to the pitch



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eight months later.

A month after Rodri's injury, FIFPRO filed a legal complaint with the European Commission, citing FIFA's "abuse of dominance," specifically related to the CWC, even though the issue is not just limited to the tournament. Many players who have not had a proper post-season break since last season (those who competed in EURO 2024) will not get one even next year, as they will have to prepare for the FIFA World Cup immediately after their club season ends.

As FIFA continues to increase competitions, an alarming pattern is emerging in which players are seeing their post-season breaks being eaten into. And this cycle will continue, with 2027 being the only year this decade not to feature a tournament after the regular club season. 2028 will see the EURO and Copa America, 2029 will have the next edition of the CWC, and 2030 will feature the centenary FIFA World Cup, jointly hosted by Morocco, Portugal and Spain (with a match each in Uruguay, Argentina and Paraguay).

Impact on the 2025-26 season

The teams that played in the CWC are concerned about the after-effects of this elongated 2024-25 season. Players have less time to recover from the physical and mental strain of a long season, including muscle fatigue and oxidative stress. This, in turn, can put them at risk of injuries next season. Clubs will now have to brainstorm how much time off they can give players, because there is also the factor of getting a few pre-season matches under the belt to gain match fitness before the new season starts. While those clubs with a deep run in the CWC should ideally allow more time off for their players, imbalances are bound to creep in that may negatively impact players. Also, more matches mean a greater risk of players getting injured, whether due to fatigue or an in-game incident. Bayern Munich's Jamal Musiala recently became a victim of the latter after suffering a horror injury during a quarterfinal clash with Paris Saint-Germain.